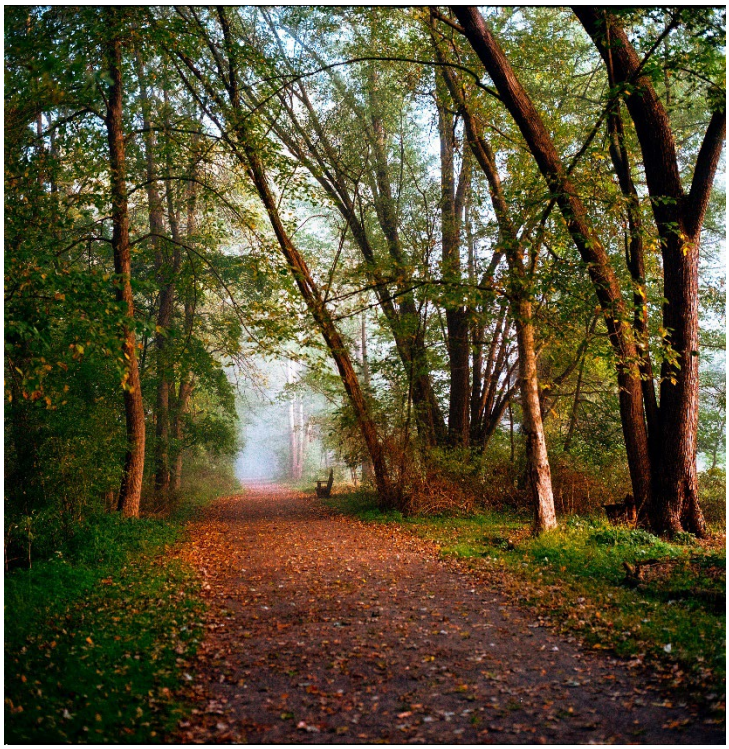
Frenchtown Sun

A Frenchtown-Focused Civic Newsletter

Borough Council to Vote on Prohibiting Data Centers in Frenchtown

On Wednesday, October 7, Borough Council voted in favor of introducing Ordinance #963, which would amend borough codes to prohibit data centers in all zones of the borough. The Council's action followed recommendations provided by the Planning Board that were prepared at the request of Mayor Brad Myhre. In a September 2, 2026, press release, Executive Director of the Association of New Jersey Environmental Commissions was quoted as saying, "To date, at least 109 New Jersey municipalities and an entire county have taken action to permanently or temporarily ban data centers." The Council's action was prompted by a combination of factors: concerns expressed by borough residents regarding environmental impacts and electricity costs, actions already taken by neighboring towns (Alexandria, Kingwood and Milford) to ban or restrict data centers, and an ongoing national conversation about data centers.

Under the New Jersey Municipal Land Use Law, municipalities are authorized [*Continued on page 5*]



Photographer: Paul Serra

From River Fox Opens Its Doors, Offers Home Goods, Seasonal Décor

With a soft opening on Friday, October 9 and opening weekend on Saturday and Sunday, October 10 and 11, From River Fox is a new home goods shop located at 33 Race St.

Owner John, with his background in interior design, and his business partner Joe, who runs Black Shed in Stockton, offer curated and found pieces that are unique and inspired by Frenchtown and the local area.

A sister shop to Black Shed, From River Fox sells fresh flowers, plants, candles, home décor, gifts and seasonal pieces. The store is lushly decorated with leafy plants and vibrant feathers and flowers. John shared that the store's name was inspired by seeing foxes running across the dunes during a visit to Provincetown, MA and he laughed saying that now he sees foxes everywhere.

From River Fox is available to help with all floral needs, you can contact contact@fromrf.com for your orders.

From River Fox is open Thursdays – Mondays from 11 a.m. – 6 p.m., hours are subject to change.

On Friday, November 20 from 5 – 8 p.m., the store will host a holiday open house replete with small bites, drinks and seasonal cheer.

Visit the store or its Instagram account @fromriverfox to learn more.

About *The Frenchtown Sun*

The Frenchtown Sun is published monthly by the Borough of Frenchtown to provide its residents with local news and community updates.

The content of *The Sun* is guided by the editorial team of Ted Brandston, Randi Eckel, the late Rick Epstein, John Gattuso, Jeanne Herb, Amelia Rodriguez and Maria Whelan. John Dougherty serves as the Borough Council liaison.

The Sun is delivered monthly free of charge to all Frenchtown Borough residents. An online edition is available at www.frenchtownsun.net.

Borough residents can request postal delivery or contact the editorial team at newsletter@frenchtownboro.com or mail *The Frenchtown Sun*, 29 Second Street, Frenchtown, N.J. 08825.

Updates from Borough Council

At its monthly meeting on October 7, Borough Council:

- heard a public statement from residents of 310 Harrison St. who experienced a fire at their home and wanted to thank the Frenchtown police and fire rescue services for their heroic efforts. All parties are OK and the residents have found new shelter in town.
- approved a funding request from the American Legion for the Halloween Parade, held on Saturday, October 24; approved the 8th St. Block Party, held on October 24; approved the "HATCH" Art Festival and Parade for May 3-10, 2027, including park reservations at Sunbeam Lenape Park and Old Frenchtown Field, and the ArtYard Tin Anniversary Gala to be held on Saturday, November 7; and approved Delaware Riverkeepers Ride Along the River for November 7 from 9 a.m. to 5 p.m.
- approved a Fire Department new member application.
- adopted a capital ordinance providing for various capital improvements to Borough Hall, appropriating $250,000 ($50,000 from the Borough's Capital Improvement Fund and $200,000 from a grant received or expected to be received from the New Jersey Department of Community Affairs.
- adopted an ordinance to amend chapter 50 "Land Use", article III "General Regulations", section 301 "Exceptions, Modifications and Supplementary Regulations" of the Borough Code to establish exceptions for permanent wheelchair ramps, first floor bathrooms and medically necessary equipment for residents with mobility limitations and health conditions.
- introduced an ordinance to amend chapter 50 "Land Use", article III "General Regulations", section 303 "Accessory Buildings and Structures" of the Borough Code to establish standards for roof-mounted solar panels. The ordinance will move to the Planning/Zoning Board for consistency review. A public hearing for this ordinance will be held at the next Council meeting on Wednesday, November 4.
- introduced an ordinance to amend chapter 50 "Land Use," article I "Title, Purpose, Administration and Definitions," section 104 "Definitions" and article III "General Regulations," section 301 "Exceptions, Modifications and Supplementary Regulations" of the Borough Code to prohibit data centers in all zones. A public hearing for the ordinance will be held at the next Council meeting on Wednesday, November 4 (*learn more about data centers on page 1*).
- approved resolutions authorizing the Mayor and Clerk to execute a federal aid agreement with NJDOT; authorized the Mayor and Clerk to sign a construction support services agreement with NV5 for the Safe Routes to School Project; approved a 2026-2027 commercial HVAC maintenance service agreement; and awarded a professional services contract for Borough Hall architectural services.
- Approved a resolution supporting the speed limit reduction on Race St./Everittstown Rd. (County Rt. 513) and Kingwood Ave. (County Rt. 610/Rt. 12) within Borough limits. All of Race St./Everittstown Rd. (County Rt. 513) within the Borough limits (both directions) meets the statutory requirements for 25 MPH speed limit. On Kingwood Ave. (County Rt. 610/Rt. 12) within the Borough limits, the following statutory speed limit requirements will apply: from Race St./Bridge St. intersection to Ridge Rd. (both directions) the statutory speed limit is 25 MPH and from Ridge Rd. to the borough [*Continued on page 7*]

Spotlight on the Frenchtown Cemetery Association and the Cemetery's History

With its main entrance on Trenton Ave., the beautiful Frenchtown Cemetery is an integral part of local history and culture. It operates as a Mutual Cemetery Company under IRS regulations and is governed by the current Trustees of the Frenchtown Cemetery Association: Timothy Downing Brown, Charles Eichlin, Leslie Stintsman, Gordon Dragt, Susie Swider and Jerry Case. Case, who served as Superintendent for over 45 years, now holds the title of Superintendent Emeritus. The board also honors the memory of Dennis Carr, a devoted trustee of 24 years who passed away in February 2026; his wife, Patricia, carries on the long-standing Carr family tradition of placing seasonal and holiday flowers on gravesites.

The cemetery does not have a religious affiliation, and it accommodates a wide range of cultural, religious and traditional needs, offering traditional burial and cremation interments. As a small non-profit that generates revenue primarily through plot sales, interment services, and modest investment yields on its funds, all proceeds are reinvested into maintaining the property, with no private stock or dividend distributions. Consistent with state law, the cemetery maintains a permanent trust funded by deposits from a fixed percentage of every grave sale. The principal deposited into the trust can never be spent; instead, it is invested to generate income that, along with donations, is used to maintain cemetery grounds. The internal roads are owned by the Cemetery Association; and the borough has no responsibility for the upkeep or maintenance of cemetery property and roads. As a registered non-profit mutual cemetery association, the cemetery is exempt from local property taxes; an outhouse next to the toolshed and a handpump connected to a well provides sewer and water services.

Given its long history in Frenchtown and its important contributions to the borough, the Frenchtown Cemetery welcomes visitors to view its grounds and explore its history while respecting the gravesites of those who are buried there. Any individual interested in purchasing a plot or making a tax-deductible donation to the Cemetery can contact: Timothy Downing Brown at 908-752-0539; or Charles Eichlin at 908-996-2308; or email frenchtowncemetery@gmail.com.



Jerry Case, Superintendent Emeritus of the Frenchtown Cemetery, and Mayor Brad Myhre, 2018. Photo Courtesy of the Bucks County Herald

Frenchtown Cemetery History

Frenchtown Cemetery originated in 1810 as a private family graveyard for the Mallet-Prevost family. The first burial recorded on the grounds was that of Jeanne Patry Mallet-Prevost, wife of Paul Henri Mallet-Prevost. For nearly five decades, the site served as the family's private resting place until 1857, when the Prevost family established the Frenchtown Cemetery Association and opened the cemetery to the public. Following its public establishment, the first recorded public burial was Isaac F. Tomson (1835-1857), whose headstone remains standing a few hundred feet past the entrance gate along the left side of the main drive. Shortly thereafter, Jacob Rounsavell (1817-1857) became the second public internee.

As Frenchtown grew, the cemetery expanded to accommodate the community. By 1880, the grounds contained more than 500 graves prompting the installation of a distinctive stone fence across the front perimeter. In 1897, local builder John L. Slack constructed the grounds' only frame structure—a wooden tool house—for $261. In 1901, the main avenue through the grounds was macadamized to improve access for funeral processions and visitors.

Among the most prominent monuments are those in memory of Private Garret Roberson, who died at the Battle of Gaines [*Continued on page 7*]

Community Calendar

SUNDAY, NOVEMBER 1
ArtYard Steamroller Group's Uncharted Territories Exhibit, 12 - 3 p.m., Apgar House, 12 Bridge St., *The exhibit runs from October 24 through November 29; hours are Thursdays through Sundays 12 – 3 p.m.; an opening celebration and poetry reading is set for November 6, 5 - 6 p.m.; Uncharted Territories is a two year long collaborative project uniting 19 poets and 21 artists, culminating in limited editions of 75 hand-bound artist books. Framed prints, broadsides and books will be for sale.*

MONDAY, NOVEMBER 2
American Legion Trivia & Cheesesteaks, 7 p.m., American Legion Fidelity Post 113, 510 Harrison St.

TUESDAY, NOVEMBER 3
- **Election Day!**
- **Super Seniors, 11 a.m. – 1:30 p.m.,** Presbyterian Church, 22 Fourth St., *Free for adults over 55; yoga with Priscilla, lunch and lecture on nutrition for seniors workshop with Valentina Valencia*

WEDNESDAY, NOVEMBER 4
Borough Council Meeting, 7 p.m., Borough Hall, 29 Second St.

THURSDAY, NOVEMBER 5
Riders Clam Night at the Legion, 5 p.m., American Legion Fidelity Post 113, 510 Harrison St., *Burgers also available; come early—clams sell out fast!*

SATURDAY, NOVEMBER 7
- **Mayor's Town Hall: Promoting an Age-Friendly Frenchtown, 10 a.m. – 12 p.m.,** Frenchtown Elementary School, 902 Harrison St., *Read more about this Town Hall on page 5; older residents who may need assistance getting to the Frenchtown Elementary School should contact the Borough Clerk at clerk@frenchtownboro.com or call 908-996-4524 and a volunteer will reach out to offer assistance.*
- **Delaware Riverkeepers Ride Along the River 2026, 10 a.m. – 5 p.m.,** Bulls Island Recreation Area, 2185 Daniel Bray Hwy., Stockton, NJ, *Check-in begins at 10 a.m.; parking is free, but first-come, first-serve; participants are required to wear a helmet, sign a DNR participation waiver and have proof of insurance. To register, visit: https://givebutter.com/RATR2026*

TUESDAY, NOVEMBER 10
Environmental Commission Meeting, 7 p.m., Borough Hall, 29 Second St.

THURSDAY, NOVEMBER 12
Planning/Zoning Board Meeting, 7 p.m., Borough Hall, 29 Second St.

SATURDAY, NOVEMBER 14
- **Frenchtown Farmers Market, 10 a.m. – 2 p.m.,** Sunbeam Lenape Park, *Note: this is the last Farmers Market of the season!*
- **Square Dance at the American Legion, 6:30 – 9:30 p.m.,** American Legion Fidelity Post 113, 510 Harrison St., *All levels welcome; hosted by the Burnt Mill Highballers*

MONDAY, NOVEMBER 16
American Legion Trivia & Cheesesteaks, 7 p.m., American Legion Fidelity Post 113, 510 Harrison St.

TUESDAY, NOVEMBER 17
- **Super Seniors, 11 a.m. – 1:30 p.m.,** Presbyterian Church, 22 Fourth St., *Free for adults over 55; yoga with Priscilla, lunch and lecture on culinary herbs, use and benefits with Rutgers Master Gardeners*
- **Frenchtown Elementary School Board of Education Meeting, 6:45 p.m.,** Frenchtown Elementary School, 902 Harrison St.

THURSDAY, NOVEMBER 19
- **Riders Clam Night at the Legion, 5 p.m.,** American Legion Fidelity Post 113, 510 Harrison St., *Burgers also available; come early—clams sell out fast!*
- **River Bridges Community Group Monthly Potluck, 6:30 p.m.,** Frenchtown Presbyterian Church, 22 Fourth St., *All are invited to this family-friendly event to share in giving thanks, feast on delicious food and to enjoy conversation with your neighbors. Please sign up at www.riverbridges.org to bring a dish to share. Please bring your own plates/cups/utensils for the benefit of the environment.*

FRIDAY, NOVEMBER 20
Delaware Valley Regional High School Theatre Presents "Clue", 7 p.m., Delaware Valley Regional High School, 19 Senator Stout Rd., *Purchase tickets prior to the show online for $12 or for $15 at the door.*

SATURDAY, NOVEMBER 21
- **Breakfast at Darcy Lodge, 8 – 11 a.m.,** 39 Everittstown Rd., *$12 per person ages 13+, $7 per person ages 6-12, children under 5 eat free; all-you-can-eat buffet.*
- **Delaware Valley Regional High School Theatre Presents "Clue", 2 p.m. & 7 p.m.,** Delaware Valley Regional High School, 19 Senator Stout Rd., *Purchase tickets prior to the show online for $12 or for $15 at the door.*

FREE for ALL Community Event a Success!

The River Bridges Community Group expresses their sincere thanks to all who participated in October's community-wide FREE for ALL event.

Over 30 area households shared items that they no longer needed with their neighbors—many items were passed along to appreciative new homes and saved from being discarded into landfills.

River Bridges is looking forward to making FREE for ALL an annual event and hoping to see more Frenchtownians next year!

News from the County Senior Center

In November, the Senior Center will celebrate Friendsgiving with a pie and ice cream social—for more information, visit: https://www.co.hunterdon.nj.us/495/Senior-Center#docaccess-ba438385277df5f5047a1a103143e670.

In addition to the Center's regularly scheduled fitness and social recreational programs and classes, specials in November include a sound healing workshop, a talk by Larry Kidder on George Washington's historic crossing and workshops on Senior Safety.

Pre-registration is required for all special events. For these and other November programs at the Senior Center, visit the Center's website at https://www.co.hunterdon.nj.us/495/Senior-Center or call 908-788-1359.

Membership to the Senior Center is free; you must be a resident of Hunterdon County and 60 years of age.

Mayor Myhre's Age-Friendly Town Hall

Join Mayor Brad Myhre and Borough Council members on Saturday, November 7 from 10:00 a.m. – 12:00 p.m. at Frenchtown Elementary School to discuss efforts underway in the borough to promote an Age-Friendly Frenchtown. The first hour of the Town Hall will focus on conversation with Mayor Myhre and Council members; the second hour will be an "open house" with a variety of government agencies and nonprofit organizations that provide services to older residents. This is a valuable opportunity for Frenchtown's older residents to learn about programs and services available to them locally. In June 2026, Borough Council adopted an Age-Friendly Action Plan that was the result of a year-long planning process supported by a grant from the New Jersey Department of Human Services: https://frenchtownboro.com/community-services/age-friendly-frenchtown/.

Coffee and snacks will be available. Borough residents who need accommodations or assistance to attend the Town Hall, please reach out to the Borough Clerk at 908-996-4524 or clerk@frenchtownboro.gov.

No Data Centers in Frenchtown?

[*Continued from page 1*] to identify permitted uses within various zones—such as residences, retail establishments, gas stations and schools. Although data centers are not currently listed as a permitted use under borough rules, rendering them disallowed by default, Borough Professional Planner Darlene Green noted that developers in other communities have circumvented local zoning by housing data centers inside warehouses. Borough Attorney Albert Cruz explained at a Council meeting that explicitly defining and prohibiting data centers provides a clear legal safeguard against such workarounds. Furthermore, the Planning Board carefully crafted the ordinance to ensure that it would not be deemed "arbitrary and capricious" in the event of a legal challenge. A key priority for both the Planning Board in its recommendations and the Borough Council in its October 7 action was addressing a pre-existing facility owned by Brightspeed. Because the facility provides phone and internet service, the ordinance ensures the facility would not be classified as a data center.

After the introduction of the ordinance at the October Borough Council meeting, the draft ordinance will return to the Planning Board for a "consistency review" to ensure alignment with the town's Master Plan. If the Planning Board finds that the ordinance is "not inconsistent" with the master plan, the ordinance will be returned to Borough Council for a public hearing at the Council's November meeting after which Council will vote to either adopt or reject the ordinance. If adopted, the ordinance will go into effect and become part of Frenchtown's municipal code.

The draft ordinance is available on the Borough website at: https://frenchtownboro.com/local-government/legal-notices/.

Nurturing Curiosity and Community: Inside Secret Garden Montessori

Frenchtown has the benefit of two vibrant preschool programs on-site within the borough. One program is offered by the Frenchtown Elementary School: the Little Paws Preschool which offers a full-day program starting at age 3 that is fully integrated into the elementary school curriculum. The second is the private Secret Garden Montessori, located at the Frenchtown Barn Theater at 1110 Harrison St., which prides itself on offering a child-centered approach to learning.

Secret Garden's story began in 2006 when a dedicated group of Delaware River Valley families partnered with Montessori educator Barbette Robillard to form a small, home-based learning cooperative. As local interest and enrollment grew, the program formalized its nonprofit structure around 2009–2010 and moved into its current home in the Barn Theater building owned by the DeSapio family. Today, the school has the capacity to serve up to 45 children—including four students who reside in Frenchtown Borough.

At the heart of Secret Garden is the educational philosophy of Dr. Maria Montessori (1870–1952), an Italian physician and educator who pioneered a method based on close observation of child development. Unlike traditional school environments, a Montessori classroom emphasizes an active role for students, who work at their own pace in mixed-age settings. The school serves children in two distinct programs: a Toddler program for ages 18 months to 3 years, and a Primary program for ages 3 to 6. A typical day features a long, uninterrupted work cycle. During this time, children select developmentally appropriate activities, working independently or in small groups with guidance from staff who hold credentials from the Princeton Center for Teacher Education. Classrooms blend traditional academic subjects—such as language, math, art and cultural studies—with practical life skills that foster independence, concentration, and social responsibility.

Secret Garden's mission is to cultivate compassionate, critical thinkers who are holistically prepared for the future. This commitment extends beyond the classroom walls through active community involvement. Students participate in gardening, service projects, and local initiatives that build meaningful connections with the surrounding environment. As the school looks toward the future, it continues to explore long-term facility plans, which could include expanding within its current location or eventually pursuing a larger permanent home in the area. For families interested in joining the community, the school maintains waiting lists for both its Toddler and Primary programs, with tuition assistance and scholarship opportunities available for eligible families.

Whether they are tending to gardens, exploring math concepts with hands-on materials, or playing at the local field, Secret Garden students represent a thriving, thoughtful chapter of Frenchtown's educational landscape. For more information on Secret Garden or to sign your child up for programs, contact info@secretgardenmontessori.org.



Environmental Commission Presented at ANJEC Environmental Congress in Sept.

As previously reported by *The Sun,* the Frenchtown Environmental Commission (FEC) received an Association of NJ Environmental Commissions (ANJEC) Open Space Stewardship grant in May of 2026 for the weevil project.

Commission member Armin Zomorodi shared a slideshow presentation at the 53rd ANJEC Environmental Congress on September 25 as part of a panel of other Open Space Stewardship Grantees.

Zomorodi participates in the FEC in hopes of improving access and stewardship of Frenchtown's green spaces and the sustainability and affordability of the town infrastructure and policies.

FES Centennial Celebration Recap

Frenchtown Elementary School (FES) held its centennial celebration on October 3. Previously scheduled for September 28, the event was postponed due to inclement weather conditions.

The event kicked off with an opening ceremony featuring the FES band and choir directed by music teacher Peggy Ippolito and an introduction from Kate Nugent, Board of Education President. The band played a series of pep tunes and the choir followed up with singing FES alma mater "Hail Frenchtown!" written by Audrey Kish-Kiley.

Michelle Liebtag, Borough Council President, Juan Torres, Hunterdon County Interim Superintendent, Jim Hintenach, Chief School Administrator and Sandy Miller, Centennial Coordinator and Secretary of FES all made remarks.

Kathy Skerbetz, a retired preschool teacher's aide, honored her great aunt Edith Ort Thomas. Ort Thomas was a math teacher and board member who served FES for over 50 years. In 1976, the school was renamed Edith Ort Thomas Elementary School in honor of her years of dedication.

Seventh grade students Avielle McAllister and Ardiana Berisha shared the history of the Spirit of the American Doughboy statue in front of the school. The statue is a memorial to Frenchtown men who served in World War I. The Doughboy was created by E. M. Viquesney, a Spanish-American War veteran and sculptor from Indiana. The sculpture represents a World War 1 infantryman and is one of eight versions of the statue in New Jersey.

"Together our school and the Doughboy remind us that history is not only something we remember; it is something we carry forward," said McCallister.

Memorabilia was arranged in the cafeteria and guests were invited to view the collection. Collected pieces included graduation pictures from when FES was a high school, yearbooks, letters and newspaper clippings that were either donated by alumni or part of FES's vast collection.

Rick Epstein's newly released book *Terriers Forever* was available for purchase. "One of our FES parents, Natasha Mikhalchuk, worked with the late Rick Epstein to write our book," said Sandy Miller.

The centennial proved to be a great way to engage the community and demonstrate the importance of FES to Frenchtown. —*Amelia Rodriguez*



Borough Council Updates from October

[*Continued from page 2*] boundary to the east (both directions), the statutory speed limit is 35 MPH.

- authorized hiring of a special council to review a proposed cannabis ordinance for potential future introduction, ensuring consistency with existing state laws and regulations; further consideration and action will proceed as funding becomes available.
- acknowledged that Council members and the DPW will update sandbox at Borough Park; Council is still working on bids for skatepark equipment.
- acknowledged that the sidewalk at the corner of Harrison St. and upper 6th St. had been repaired.
- shared that after saving animals from the fire on 301 Harrison St., the Police and Fire Departments are putting in a request for animal masks.

The Borough Administrator and Public Safety Director has resigned. Sgt. Eccles serves as the officer in charge. All other needs and questions can be directed to Borough Hall.

Frenchtown Cemetery's Monuments Dedicated to Fallen Soldiers

[*Continued from page 3*] Mills in 1862; Robert Rittenhouse, who was "lost at sea" in 1935 when the USS Havana ran aground on a reef in the Bahamas; and of Private William Finney Jr. and other victims of a spinal meningitis outbreak at Jefferson Barracks in Missouri in 1907. Today, the cemetery spans approximately 14.5 acres and serves as the final resting place for nearly 5,800 individuals. —*Excerpt courtesy of* Frenchtown *and* More Frenchtown *by Rick Epstein.*

Stink Bugs: A Friendly Houseguest

This time of year, many folks are vexed by large brown-colored stink bugs trying to get into their houses. This is a fairly new problem—caused by an invasive species, the Brown Marmorated Stink Bug (*Halyomorpha halys*). This Asian insect was accidentally introduced into the United States and first found in North America nearby in Allentown, PA, in 1996 (having likely been introduced on packing material from overseas). Since then, this insect has spread throughout much of the United States and become a pest of various fruits, field crops and ornamental plants.

Adult Marmorated Stink Bugs are fairly easy to identify—they are just under an inch long and shaped like a shield. The adults enter houses in the fall simply looking for a protected space to spend the winter. Because they feed exclusively on plants, they cannot harm people or pets. As a matter of fact, they scarcely feed during the winter months and do not reproduce—but they certainly can become a nuisance: walking around, being crushed underfoot, flying to lights. Like all stink bugs, they only emit a foul smell when disturbed or crushed. Because of the smell, it is best not to crush them. To move them, you can gently catch them for release outside or vacuum them up (although vacuuming them may cause a stink!).

It should be noted that our native stink bugs are, by and large, much better behaved and do not try to enter our houses in the winter. Hunterdon County is home to quite a few native species of (characteristically shield shaped) stink bugs: the Green, Brown, Juniper, Harlequin, Anchor, Twice Stabbed, Elf Shoe, Tuxedo, Spined Soldier and others. Most of these also feed by sucking plant sap through their piercing-sucking mouthparts, and a few of them, like the Spined Soldier Bugs, are predatory on other insects. But all of these native insects go about their lives in our gardens and woodlands without us ever noticing—it is only the introduced Marmorated Stink Bug that invades our houses in the fall. —*Randi Eckel*



Photo Courtesy of David R Land, USDA APHIS PPQ, www.bugwood.org

Frenchtown Sun
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